

The Exorcism of Emily Rose

Extreme Ultra-Density Draft: Chapters 5 & 6

CHAPTER 5: OPENING

The courtroom was a theater, and Erin Bruner knew her blocking.

She knew exactly where the light hit the defense table at 9:00 AM. She knew which floorboard creaked near the jury box (third from the left, a sharp *E-flat* squeak). She knew that if she stood at a forty-five-degree angle to the judge, she looked respectful; if she stood head-on, she looked aggressive.

Today, she needed to be something else.

She needed to be the Bridge.

The bailiff called the court to order. "All rise."

The sound of a hundred people standing up at once was like a sudden gust of wind. Fabric rustling. Shoes scuffing. The collective intake of breath.

Judge Brewster swept in. He was a small man in a big robe, but he wore the authority like a second skin. He sat down.

"Be seated."

The crowd sat.

"Mr. Thomas," Brewster said. "The People may open."

Owen Thomas stood up.

He didn't walk to the jury box immediately. He took a moment. He buttoned his jacket. He touched the file on his desk—the file with the photo of Emily Rose. It was a grounding gesture. A reminder of why he was here.

He walked to the well of the court.

He looked like a statue of Justice carved from granite. Solid. Dependable. Immovable.

"Ladies and gentlemen," he began. His voice was a deep baritone that filled the room without shouting. It resonated in the chest. "This is a simple case."

He paused. He let the word *simple* hang in the air.

"It is a tragic case. A heartbreaking case. But it is simple."

He walked to the evidence table. He picked up a small orange bottle. The plastic rattled.

"This," he said, holding it up to the light, "is Gambrolic. It is a medication used to treat epilepsy and psychosis. It stabilizes the electrical storms in the brain. It calms the mind. It saves lives."

He set the bottle down on the railing of the jury box. *Clack.*

The sound was loud in the silence.

"Emily Rose had a medical condition. A serious, treatable condition. She went to doctors. She underwent tests. She got a prescription. And for a time... she was getting better."

Owen turned. He walked slowly toward the defense table. His eyes locked onto Father Moore.

Moore didn't blink. He sat in his black cassock, a shadow in the bright room.

"Then," Owen said, his voice hardening, "she met this man."

The jury looked at Moore. Erin watched them. Juror 4 (The Mechanic) frowned. Juror 11 (The Nurse) touched her wrist, her fingers brushing the medical alert bracelet.

"Father Richard Moore," Owen continued, pointing a finger that accused not just the man, but the institution he represented. "He told her that her medicine was poison. He told her that her seizures were not a disease, but a gift. A curse. A possession."

Owen walked back to the jury. He leaned in, his hands gripping the railing.

"He told a sick, vulnerable nineteen-year-old girl to stop eating. He told her that food was 'feeding the demon.' He tied her to a bed with leather straps. He watched her waste away for weeks. He watched her weight drop from one hundred and twenty pounds to sixty-eight pounds."

A gasp from the gallery. Sixty-eight pounds. It was a number that defied biology.

"And when she died," Owen said, his voice dropping to a whisper that carried more weight than a scream, "he didn't call 911. He didn't call a doctor. He prayed."

He straightened up. He looked at the jury with eyes that burned with righteous anger.

"We respect faith in this country. But we do not allow superstition to override the law. We do not allow negligence to masquerade as piety. We ask you to look at the facts. And the facts say that Emily Rose did not have to die. She was killed. Not by a demon. But by the man who was supposed to save her."

Owen Thomas sat down.

The courtroom was silent. Heavy.

It was a devastating opening. A wall of logic. A fortress of morality.

"Ms. Bruner?" Judge Brewster said.

Erin stood up.

She felt the weight of the room. The eyes of the press. The eyes of the Church. The eyes of the dead girl.

She didn't walk to the jury box. Not yet.

She walked to the witness stand. She touched the empty chair. The wood was polished, smooth under her fingertips.

"Facts," she said.

Her voice was cool. Clear water.

"Mr. Thomas has given you facts. Emily was sick. She stopped her meds. She died."

She turned slowly to face the jury.

"Facts are powerful things. They are bricks. You can build a wall with them. Mr. Thomas is building a wall. He wants to wall off the things we don't understand. He wants to tell you that everything in this world—every pain, every vision, every death—can be explained by a pill in an orange bottle."

She walked to the center of the room. She stood in the pool of light.

"But we know... don't we? In the quiet of the night, when the house settles and the dark presses against the window... we know that isn't true."

She saw Juror 8 (The Graduate Student) look up from his hands. He was listening.

She saw Juror 11 (The Nurse) stop rubbing her wrist.

"We will show you that Emily Rose was not a victim of negligence. She was a victim of something science could not name. Something medicine could not cure. Father Moore didn't tell her to stop eating. *Something else* stopped her."

Erin walked to the defense table. She stood behind Father Moore. She put a hand on his shoulder.

The fabric of his cassock was rough. Cheap wool. He felt frail under her hand. Human.

"Mr. Thomas calls this man a killer," Erin said. "He calls him a fanatic."

She looked at Owen.

"I call him a witness."

She turned back to the jury.

"We will present evidence that will challenge your view of reality. We will show you testimony that sounds impossible. We will play you a tape..."

She paused. The word *tape* hung there. A promise of horror.

"...a recording of the night Emily died. And when you hear it... when you hear the voice that spoke through that girl... you will have to make a choice."

She walked to the jury rail. She looked Juror 11 in the eye.

"You can choose the wall," Erin whispered. "You can choose the safety of the orange bottle. Or... you can choose to look over the edge. You can choose to see the possibility... that Father Moore was not killing Emily Rose. He was the only one who was truly trying to save her."

Erin stood there for a beat. Holding the silence. Letting the doubt take root.

Then she nodded.

"Thank you."

She walked back to her seat. *Click-clack. Click-clack.*

She sat down.

Karl leaned over.

"You built the bridge," he whispered.

"Now I just have to make them walk across it," Erin said.

She looked at her hands. They were steady.

But under the table, her leg was bouncing. *Tap-tap-tap.*

Because she knew what was coming.

She knew about the tape. She knew about the barn.

And she knew that once she led them across that bridge, there was no turning back.

The wall was safe.

The bridge led to the dark.

CHAPTER 6: EXHIBIT A - THE PHOTOGRAPH

****[INTERSTITIAL DOCUMENT: STATE'S EXHIBIT A]****

The envelope was Manila. Standard issue. Stamped *CONFIDENTIAL*.

Erin sat in her condo. It was late. The city outside was a blurred grid of rain and light.

She had the file open on her coffee table.

The photo was face down.

She had looked at it a dozen times. Every time, it felt like touching a live wire.

She reached out. Her finger hovered over the glossy paper.

She flipped it over.

****SUBJECT:**** Emily Rose.

****DATE:**** November 1, 1976.

****LOCATION:**** Rose Farmhouse, Bedroom 2 (The Barn).

****PHOTOGRAPHER:**** Detective J. Miller.

The photo was black and white, but Erin's mind filled in the colors.

The girl lay on a military-style cot. The canvas was stained.

She was nineteen.

She looked ninety.

Her body was a map of devastation. A landscape of bone and bruise.

The ribs were not just visible; they were aggressive. They pushed against the skin like the bars of a cage, as if trying to escape the body that held them. The hip bones were razor blades. The stomach was a concave hollow.

Malnutrition, the report said. *Starvation.*

But starvation was a passive word. It implied a lack.

This looked active. This looked like she had been *consumed*. Eaten from the inside out.

Erin traced the injuries with her eyes.

1. ****The Face:**** There were lacerations on the lips and cheeks. Deep, jagged tears. The Medical Examiner said they were self-inflicted. *Biting.* She had bitten through her own lip. Why? To stop the

words? Or because the hunger for filth was so strong she tried to eat herself?

2. ****The Wrists:**** Bands of purple bruising. The skin was abraded, raw, weeping serum. The leather restraints. They had tied her down. To protect her? Or to hold her down for the thing that was riding her?

3. ****The Knees:**** This was the worst part. This was the detail that made Erin's stomach clench.

The knees were destroyed.

They were swollen to twice their normal size, dark spheres of hematoma. The skin had split.

The report was clinical: *Bilateral rupture of the patellar tendons. Commuted fractures of the patella.*

She had knelt.

She had knelt on the hard wooden floor of the barn.

For hours. For days.

Genuflection.

Six hundred times a day.

Up. Down. Up. Down.

Until the tendons snapped like wet rubber bands. Until the bone ground against the wood.

Why?

Because He commands it, Moore had said.

Or because the Demon wanted to break the vessel. To mock the posture of prayer by turning it into an instrument of torture.

4. ****The Eyes:****

The eyes were open.

In the flash of the police camera, the pupils were blown wide, encompassing the iris. Two black holes.

The whites of the eyes—the sclera—were not white. They were dark.

Subconjunctival hemorrhage.

Broken blood vessels.

From screaming.

She had screamed so hard, for so long, that her eyes had bled.

Erin looked at the face.

It wasn't a face of peace. It wasn't the "sleeping beauty" of fairy tales.

It was a face of absolute, total exhaustion.

But...

Erin leaned closer. She picked up a magnifying glass.

She looked at the corner of the mouth.

There was a slight upturn.

A millimeter of muscle tension.

Was it a rictus? A spasm of the dying nerves?

Or was it... a smile?

Maria Rose swore she was smiling.

She saw something beautiful, Maria had said.

Erin looked at the black holes of the eyes.

What did you see, Emily?

Did you see the Virgin?

Or did you see the bottom of the pit?

Erin took a pen. She wrote in the margin of the photocopy.

Her handwriting was jagged.

Look at the hands.

She circled the hands.

They weren't clawed. They weren't fighting the straps.

They were open.

Palms up.

Resting on the cot.

The posture of acceptance. The posture of a martyr waiting for the fire.

This isn't a victim, Erin wrote.

This is a volunteer.

She closed the file.

The face of Emily Rose disappeared into the Manila darkness.

But the afterimage remained.

The black eyes. The broken knees.

The smile.

Erin looked at the empty Eames chair in the corner of her room.

She felt the copper taste in her mouth.

"She accepted it," Erin whispered to the empty room.

"But I don't."

She stood up. She grabbed her wine glass.

She drank.

But the wine tasted like blood.